



DEFENSE COUNTERINTELLIGENCE AND SECURITY AGENCY

VOICE OF INDUSTRY

DCSA MONTHLY NEWSLETTER

July 2024

Dear Facility Security Officer (FSO) (sent on behalf of your Industrial Security Representative (ISR)),

DCSA Industrial Security (IS) publishes the monthly Voice of Industry (VOI) newsletter to provide recent information, policy guidance, and security education and training updates for facilities in the National Industrial Security Program (NISP). Please let us know if you have questions or comments. VOIs are posted on DCSA's website on the [NISP Tools & Resources](#) page, as well as in the National Industrial Security System (NISS) Knowledge Base. For more information on all things DCSA, visit www.dcsa.mil.

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NATIONAL BACKGROUND INVESTIGATION SERVICES (NBIS)

UNACCEPTABLE CASE COMMENTS NOW AVAILABLE

Effective July 17, FSOs will see specific case comments when a request is returned as unacceptable from DCSA. When an investigation request is returned from the Investigation Service Provider (ISP) for correction, the reason and case comment will be presented in the Unacceptable Case Notice section at the bottom of the Review tab. As illustrated below, users will see the reason for the unacceptable case and a case comment that provides specific information for the unacceptable case.

Field	Section	Details	Warning
> Schools Attended, Degrees Obtained	12 - Where You Went To School	The subject has listed no schools attended or past degrees/diplomas obtained.	Requires Review
Unacceptable Case Notice			
Reasons for Unacceptable 1A - FORM NOT SUBMITTED		Case Comments CASE HAS BEEN MARKED AS UNACCEPTABLE FINGERPRINTS NOT SUBMITTED	

FSOs can use this information to correct the request and resubmit or return the request to DCSA to schedule a background investigation.

NEGATIVE CASE TIMERS

As part of development for NBIS 4.6.5, the issues identified with global expiration timer countdowns has been corrected. The hotfix ensures cases which pass the designated global timers will expire as intended. Currently, there are cases that may show a negative number of days until expiration and users can expect to see these being cleaned up over the next few weeks. Users should ensure that cases released to DCSA for a background investigation have not passed 120 days from the date of certification or the request will be returned unacceptable.

NBIS VERSIONS 4.6.5 AND 4.7 RELEASED

NBIS Releases 4.6.5 and 4.7 were deployed on June 28 and July 2 respectively. These releases add enhanced capabilities for organization management, subject management, and case initiation. Additional information can be found on the [NBIS News Page](#) to include Fact Sheets outlining the new capabilities.

ADDITIONAL INSTRUCTIONS TO APPLICANT

Part of the NBIS 4.7 Release includes the capability for Initiators to add up to 4,000 characters of free text that will be included in emails sent to subjects. It is available on the "Routing Details" tab, through a free text box titled "Additional Instructions to the Applicant."

NBIS TRAINING RESOURCES

All NBIS training resources are available on the Security Training, Education, and Professional Portal ([STEPP](#)). Access to STEPP requires an account, and the site is accessible via a secure Smart Card Login. For any issues accessing STEPP, contact the STEPP Help Desk at 202-753-0845 (M-F 8:30 a.m. to 6:00 p.m. ET).



Once on the [STEPP NBIS Training Homepage](#), users will find a comprehensive training library which includes job aids, e-learning, video shorts, learner paths, webinar recordings, and registration for live webinars.

NBIS Training Updates:

- Training materials for Releases 4.6.5 and 4.7 are being updated and posted to STEPP. Check out the NBIS Training Catalog on STEPP for updates.
- DISS eLearning modules can now be accessed on STEPP via the NBIS Training landing page.
- Live NBIS webinars are held weekly on topics such as NBIS Education, and Case Initiation and Review. Recordings of these and other webinars are currently on STEPP. Login to STEPP to register and to find the recordings.

Be on the lookout for the NBIS Training Newsletter, which is sent via email to all NBIS users on a monthly basis. Current and previous newsletters can be found on www.dcsa.mil under NBIS Training. For questions about NBIS Training, contact the NBIS Training Program at dcsa.quantico.nbis.mbx.training@mail.mil.

SECURITY RATING PROCESS REFINEMENTS

On June 10, DCSA [announced](#) the successful joint development of a Security Rating Scorecard in cooperation with the National Industrial Security Program Policy Advisory Committee (NISPPAC) national working group. This scorecard will not change any aspect of the current security review process and will be implemented on October 1, 2024.

These refinements are not a response to process deficiencies, rather they reflect DCSA's ongoing commitment to partnering with industry to enhance clarity, fairness, and transparency within the security framework governing the NISP. The scorecard is designed to streamline and simplify the security rating process for all stakeholders. Beginning October 1, 2024, the refined process will include the introduction of a numeric rating score and enhanced criteria definitions to ensure consistent understanding and application.

DCSA has rolled out comprehensive communication and training initiatives to ensure all stakeholders are well-informed about these changes. To learn more about the refined security rating process:

- Review the [Security Rating Process Slick Sheet](#), the [Security Rating Criteria Reference Card](#), and other resources located on the DCSA Security Review & Rating [webpage](#) under the Future Rating Process tab.
- Review the [recording](#) for the CDSE "Introduction to the Security Rating Score" webinar that was held on June 25.
- Register to attend future security rating webinars [here](#).



SAFEGUARDING AUSTRALIA'S MILITARY SECRETS

The DCSA International & Special Programs team recognizes the crucial need to share recent developments in global security. While the changes to Australia's defence [British spelling] legislation may not directly impact our U.S. citizens or our cleared industry, they serve as an instructive example. Australia's proactive approach, exemplified by the implementation of Part IXAA of the Australia Defence Act 1903, underscores the growing emphasis on safeguarding military secrets in our interconnected world.

This approach parallels and resonates with our own efforts under the National Defense Authorization Act (NDAA), where we prioritize protecting national security information to ensure the integrity of our defense industrial base. By disseminating this information to our industry partners, we foster awareness, encourage best practices, and highlight the evolving landscape of international security. Even when legislative shifts do not immediately or directly affect our operations, staying informed allows us to uphold our commitment to excellence and vigilance. Additionally, recent initiatives in the United States have similarly aimed at protecting skills, knowledge, and information under the International Trade in Arms Regulation (ITAR) and the Export Administration Regulation (EAR), reflecting a global trend towards heightened security measures.

From our Industrial Security Partners in Australia:

On May 6, 2024, Part IXAA of the Australia Defence Act 1903 commenced requiring certain individuals to assess their requirements for a foreign work authorisation. The requirement for a foreign work authorisation strengthens Australia's security by preventing individuals from disclosing or exploiting classified military or related information. Individuals requiring a foreign work authorisation are required to submit their request by August 7, 2024.

Some Australian citizens and permanent residents may need to apply for a foreign authorisation when working for, or on behalf of, a foreign military or government body. Organisations and companies operating in and outside of Australia should consider if their personnel, contractors, or subcontractors are impacted by the new legislation. More information about this new Australia legislation and how those impacted should apply can be found [here](#).

GUIDELINES FOR RESEARCH SECURITY PROGRAMS

On July 9, the White House Office of Science and Technology Policy issued guidelines to federal research agencies on research security programs at certain universities and federally-funded research institutions to address risks posed by strategic competitors to the U.S. research and development (R&D) enterprise.

These guidelines help raise baseline security standards for Covered Institutions throughout the R&D enterprise that our cleared universities, University Affiliated Research Centers, and Federally Funded Research and Development Centers have applied throughout their tenure in the NISP. While these changes benefit the United States and the Defense Industrial Base, and, ultimately, our work in the NISP, we are grateful for the role that NISP entities focused on R&D have played in this environment since WWII.

The Guidelines for Research Security Programs at Covered Institutions can be found [here](#).



CASE STUDIES SHOWING PRC TRADECRAFT IN ACTION

On July 8, the National Security Agency (NSA) joined the Australian Signals Directorate (ASD) and other agencies to publish a Cybersecurity Advisory (CSA) detailing the tradecraft used by a cyber actor group associated with the People's Republic of China (PRC) Ministry of State Security (MSS). [The NSA Press Release may be viewed [here](#).] "PRC MSS Tradecraft in Action" helps cybersecurity practitioners prevent, identify, and remediate intrusions against their own networks by sharing significant case studies of the adversary's tactics and techniques. The cyber actor group has targeted organizations in various countries, including the United States and Australia. The full report may be viewed at [APT40 Advisory - PRC MSS Tradecraft in Action](#).

NATIONAL ACCESS ELSEWHERE SECURITY OVERSIGHT CENTER (NAESOC)

NAESOC WEBSITE UPDATES

Is there an issue you would like to escalate at the NAESOC? The [NAESOC web page](#) contains an escalation button which you can use to raise the priority on an issue or to query a subject that was already submitted. You can also direct escalation issues to: dcsa.ncr.is.mbx.naesoc@mail.mil.

FIELD OFFICE ASSIGNMENT AND CONTACT

NAESOC facilities are scheduled to undergo security reviews. Your facility may receive NISS notifications supporting an update in the identification of the local DCSA field office and be temporarily reassigned to that field office. This supports the communication and task workflows within NISS during security review activities. NISS users should review their NISS profile to identify their current DCSA Field Office and ISR and directly contact them as appropriate. If you have any questions about who is providing your industrial security oversight or notifications you received from NISS, please feel free to contact us directly at the NAESOC Help Desk:

- Phone (888) 282-7682, Option 7
Monday through Thursday - 9:00 a.m. to 3:00 p.m. ET
Friday - 8:00 a.m. to 2:00 p.m. ET
- Or use NISS Messaging
- Or email dcsa.naesoc.generalmailbox@mail.mil



ADJUDICATION AND VETTING SERVICES

RENAMING OF CAS AND VRO

DCSA Consolidated Adjudications Services (CAS) and Vetting Risk Operations (VRO) have united to form Adjudication and Vetting Services (AVS). AVS promises to deliver enhanced service offerings, improved response times, and optimized case management for our customers. Leadership is carefully managing the transition to ensure service continues without interruption.

NEW SF-312 JOB AID

NISP contractor personnel may now sign SF-312s using a DoD Sponsored/Approved External Certificate Authority (ECA) Public Key Infrastructure (PKI):

- The use of digital signatures on the SF-312 is optional. Manual or wet signatures will still be accepted by AVS.
- If the Subject digitally signs the SF-312, the witness block does not require a signature.
- Digital signatures must be from the list of DoD Sponsored/Approved ECA PKI located [here](#).
- The public list of DoD approved external PKIs that are authorized to digitally sign the SF-312 can be located [here](#).

The [Job Aid](#) and [OUSD I&S Memorandum](#) are available on the DCSA Website.

UPDATE ON CONDITIONAL ELIGIBILITY DETERMINATIONS

In February 2024, DCSA AVS began granting Conditional National Security Eligibility Determinations for NISP contractors. "Conditionals" provide increased mission resiliency to our customers by diverting national security cases from due process to monitoring provided by the DCSA Continuous Vetting (CV) Program. An update on the process and fact sheet can be seen [here](#).

NEW AVS CALL CENTER NUMBER

The AVS Call Center has a new phone number. The new number is 667-424-3850. The old number is still active but will be deactivated in the near future.

As a reminder, the AVS Call Center will continue to provide direct support and timely adjudicative updates to Senior Management Official (SMO) and FSOs worldwide. The AVS Call Center is available to answer phone and email inquiries from SMOs/FSOs, provide instant resolution on issues identified by Security Offices whenever possible, and serves as the POC for HSPD12/Suitability Inquiries.

The AVS Call Center is available from Monday through Friday between 6:30 a.m. and 5:00 p.m. ET to answer phone and email inquiries from FSOs only. Contact the AVS Call Center by phone at 667-424-3850 (SMOs and FSOs ONLY; no subject callers), or via email at dcsa.meade.cas.mbx.call-center@mail.mil.

For Industry PIN Resets, contact the Applicant Knowledge Center at 878-274-5091 or via email at DCSAAKC@mail.mil.



REMINDER ON TIMING OF ELECTRONIC FINGERPRINT TRANSMISSION

As we move closer to full implementation of Trusted Workforce 2.0, AVS continues to work diligently to partner with Industry to get cleared people to work faster and more efficiently all while effectively managing risk. To maintain our interim determination timeliness goals, we ask that electronic fingerprints be submitted at the same time or just before an investigation request is released to DCSA in DISS.

Fingerprint results are valid for 120 days, the same amount of time for which eApp signature pages are valid. Therefore, submitting electronic fingerprint at the same time or just before you complete your review for adequacy and completeness, should prevent an investigation request from being rejected for missing fingerprints.

CENTER FOR DEVELOPMENT OF SECURITY EXCELLENCE (CDSE)

JULY PULSE NOW AVAILABLE

We recently published the CDSE Pulse, a monthly security awareness newsletter that features topics of interest to the security community. In addition, we share upcoming courses, webinars, and conferences. The July newsletter focused on "Certification." Check out all the newsletters in [CDSE's Electronic Library](#) or subscribe/update your current subscription to get the newsletter sent directly to your inbox by submitting your email address from [CDSE News](#).

REGISTER FOR 2024 DCSA CONFERENCE FOR INSIDER THREAT

Registration is open for the DCSA Conference for Insider Threat in support of National Insider Threat Awareness Month (NITAM). The conference theme is "Deter, Detect, Mitigate" and will be held in-person and virtually on September 9-10. Registration for in-person attendance for this event will close August 26. Visit the [registration website](#) to learn more about the event and register and view the [NITAM website here](#).

INSTRUCTOR-LED CYBERSECURITY COURSE AT CDSE IN SEPTEMBER

CDSE is offering an instructor-led course on Assessing Risk and Applying Security Controls to NISP Systems (CS301.01) in September. This course is tuition free and runs September 9-13 in Linthicum, MD. Students should have completed enrollment (prerequisites and registration) by August 15.

The target audience for this training includes Information System Security Managers (ISSMs), Information System Security Officers, and FSOs involved in the planning, management, and execution of security programs for cleared industry. This 5-day course provides students with guidance on applying policies and standards used throughout the U.S. Government to protect information within computer systems, as delineated by the risk management framework process.

Go [here](#) to learn more, register, and view the required prerequisites.



PERSONNEL VETTING SEMINAR

CDSE is presenting the virtual instructor-led Personnel Vetting Seminar on August 20-22 and September 10-12. This seminar is presented to address the requirements associated with the reform of the Federal Government's personnel vetting system, which is known as Trusted Workforce 2.0 (TW 2.0). Its purpose is to aid personnel vetting practitioners in DoD, federal agencies, and private industry to understand TW 2.0 requirements, identify gaps between current and future procedures, and provide support through the implementation process. The seminar covers topics such as end-to-end personnel vetting operations, including the federal background investigations program, National Security Adjudications, Continuous Vetting, and Insider Threat analysis in a collaborative environment.

This 3-day course is intended for U.S. Government security professionals, military personnel, cleared industry FSOs, and other federal personnel performing personnel vetting security-related duties, as well as personnel executing security programs for cleared industry. Visit the [course page](#) to learn more and register.

GETTING STARTED SEMINAR FOR NEW FACILITY SECURITY OFFICERS (FSOS)

CDSE is hosting the virtual instructor-led Getting Started Seminar from August 20-23. This 4-day course allows new FSOs and security personnel the opportunity to learn and apply fundamental NISP requirements in a collaborative environment. It also serves as a refresher on industrial security basics for experienced FSOs. Areas of focus include the DD 254, Insider Threat, reporting requirements, counterintelligence, security and contractor reviews, security training and briefings, and personnel security. Visit the course page to [sign up](#) and learn about the NISP requirements for FSOs.

UPCOMING WEBINARS

Sign-up is available for the following [upcoming live webinars](#):

Kicking Off a CUI Awareness Campaign
August 1, 2024
12:00 p.m. to 1:00 p.m. ET

Security Rating Score Tool and Resources
August 29, 2024
1:00 p.m. to 2:30 p.m. ET

Mass Shooter Contagion Theory and the Copycat Effect in the Evolving Media Environment
September 5, 2024
12:00 pm to 1:30 pm ET

Security Professional Trusted Workforce 2.0 Gap Training
September 17, 2024
1:00 p.m. to 2:30 p.m. ET



CDSE NEWS

CDSE offers an email subscriber news service to get the latest CDSE news, updates, and information. You may be receiving the Pulse through a subscription, but if you were forwarded this newsletter from another source and would like to subscribe to the Pulse or one of our other products, visit [CDSE News](#) and sign up or update your account to receive:

- The Pulse
- Insider Threat Bulletins
- The Flash

SOCIAL MEDIA

Connect with us on social media!

DCSA X (formerly known as Twitter): [@DCSAgov](#)

CDSE X (formerly known as Twitter): [@TheCDSE](#)

DCSA Facebook: [@DCSAgov](#)

CDSE Facebook: [@TheCDSE](#)

DCSA LinkedIn: <https://www.linkedin.com/company/dcsagov/>

CDSE LinkedIn: <https://www.linkedin.com/showcase/cdse/>

REMINDERS

SAFEGUARD OUR INNOVATION

On July 24, the Office of the Director of National Intelligence's (ODNI) National Counterintelligence and Security Center (NCSC) issued a joint bulletin with ODNI's Office of Economic Security and Emerging Technology (OESSET), the Air Force Office of Special Investigations (AFOSI), and the Naval Criminal Investigative Service (NCIS) to protect U.S. emerging technology startups from investment by foreign threat actors.

"U.S. emerging tech startups are at the forefront of American innovation, but they face risks when seeking potential foreign investment to expand their firms. Unfortunately, our adversaries continue to exploit early-stage investments in U.S. startups to take their sensitive data. These actions threaten U.S. economic and national security and can directly lead to the failure of these companies. Today's bulletin highlights this evolving threat and provides guidance for startups to secure their innovation as they grow," said NCSC Director Michael Casey.

The [joint bulletin](#) provides information on this threat, as well as potential indicators, mitigation steps, and where to report incidents.



FACILITIES MAY ADVERTISE EMPLOYEE POSITION PCLS

In accordance with Title 32 of the Code of Federal Regulations Part 117.9(a)(9), a contractor is permitted to advertise employee positions that require a PCL in connection with the position. Separately, 32 CFR Part 117.9(a)(9) states “A contractor will not use its favorable entity eligibility determination [aka its Facility Clearance] for advertising or promotional purposes.”

DO NOT SEARCH FOR CLASSIFIED IN THE PUBLIC DOMAIN

Per the principles the 2017 DCSA (then DSS) Notice to Contractors Cleared Under the NISP on Inadvertent Exposure to Classified in the Public Domain, NISP contractors are reminded to not search for classified in the public domain.

NISP CHECKUP

The granting of a Facility Clearance (FCL) is an important accomplishment and its anniversary marks a good time to do a NISP checkup for reporting requirements. During your FCL anniversary month, DCSA will send out the Annual Industry Check-Up Tool as a reminder to check completion of reporting requirements outlined in 32 CFR Part 117, National Industrial Security Program Operating Manual.

The tool will help you recognize reporting that you need to do. DCSA recommends you keep the message as a reminder throughout the year in case things change and reminds cleared contractors that changes should be reported as soon as they occur. You will find information concerning the Tool in a link in NISS. If you have any questions on reporting, contact your assigned ISR.

This tool does not replace for or count as your self-inspection, as it is only a tool to determine report status. An additional note regarding self-inspections, they will help identify and reduce the number of vulnerabilities found during your DCSA annual security review. Please ensure your SMO certifies the self-inspection and that it is annotated as complete in NISS.

DCSA ORGANIZATION NAME CHANGES

Organization (Old)	Organization (New)
Entity Vetting	Entity Vetting
Facility Clearance Branch (FCB)	Verification and Triage Unit (VTU)
Business Analysis Unit (BAU)	Due Diligence Unit (DDU)
Mitigation Strategy Unit (MSU)	Risk Management Unit (RMU)
NISP Authorization Office (NAO)	NISP Cybersecurity Office (NCSO)
Command Cyber Readiness Inspection (CCRI)	Cyber Operational Readiness Assessment (CORA)
Programs, Plans and Strategy (PPS)	Industrial Security Technologies and Strategy (ISTS)
Operations Division (Ops)	NISP Mission Performance (NMP)
Operations Branch	Mission Branch
Consolidated Adjudications Services (CAS) and Vetting Risk Operations (VRO)	Adjudication and Vetting Services (AVS)